

Rapid defeat

The Arab armies that swept northward in the 630s faced far less resistance than they would have half a century earlier. Provinces fell easily as weakened garrisons and the doubtful loyalty of citizens undermined resistance. Although relatively small in number and lightly armed, the Arab armies were very mobile and did not need to defend fixed positions, giving them a huge advantage over their opponents. When they defeated the Byzantines at Yarmuk in 636, the whole edifice of imperial control in Palestine and Syria came crashing down. In the case of Persia, it took Arab generals just nine years to dismember the Sassanid Empire.

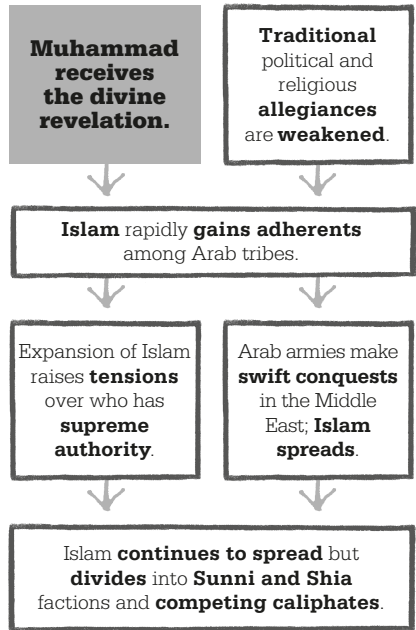
Islamic society

The newly conquered lands became part of an Islamic caliphate. Many of its inhabitants converted, while those who did not were tolerated if they were Christians, Jews, or Zoroastrians, provided they paid a special tax. Islam transformed the lands it absorbed in many ways. As well as sweeping away the old imperial structures, it imparted a new sense of religious community, often uniting the conquerors and the conquered. Islamic scholars resurrected the works of Greek philosophers and scientists that had languished forgotten for centuries, translating them into Arabic, and beautiful mosques began to adorn the towns. Areas that had been marginalized under the Byzantine or Sassanid Empires now found themselves at the heart of a new, vibrant civilization.

Success, however, brought its own problems for Islam. Acquiring lands far more urbanized than Arabia meant that the caliphs had to adapt from being warrior chiefs commanding a tight-knit group of followers, to monarchs ruling over a huge area with complex economies and societies. In addition to this, Muslims were initially in the minority, and not wholly united.

Growing divisions

Tensions over the succession to the caliphate resulted in a major schism in Islam. A struggle between Ali, Muhammad's son-in-law, and Muawiya, the Governor of Syria, led to a civil war that ended in Ali's murder and Muawiya taking



control of the caliphate in 661. While Muawiya's descendants (the Umayyads) ruled from the Syrian city of Damascus, Ali's followers opposed their authority, claiming the caliph should be chosen from among Ali's offspring. After the murder of Ali's son Husayn at Karbala in 680, the split between the Shia (those who supported the right of Ali's descendants to rule the caliphate) and the more mainstream Sunni (who rejected this) became definitive—a division that continues to this day.

Islamic unity was fractured in other ways, too; ruling over such a vast empire was almost impossible when messages from the eastern and western extremities might take months to reach the caliph's court. Independent Muslim dynasties emerged in peripheral areas and rival caliphs appeared in the 10th century in Spain and Egypt. Yet even though its political unity had been shattered, and its religious unity compromised, Muhammad's creed was so popular and successful that by the 21st century there were about 1.5 billion Muslims worldwide. ■